



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Classical Charter Schools of Whiteville
School Website: <https://ccswhiteville.net/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary TL;DR

- **School:** Classical Charter Schools of Whiteville (NC)
- **Overall Classicality:** **NOT CLASSICAL**
- **Why:**
 - The crawl shows a **state□accountability, data□driven charter** with heavy emphasis on **standardized testing, proficiency data, MTSS, social□emotional/mental□health frameworks, and "traditional values"** but **no evidence of**:
 - * Transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty), virtue, wisdom, wonder, or scholé.
 - * Theology, liturgy, chapel, or any religious/metaphysical grounding.
 - * Trivium/Quadrivium, Latin, Great Books, or Great Conversation.
 - * Socratic seminars, chanting, memory work, or rhetoric as an art.
 - Language is dominated by **negative lexicon indicators**: "standardized tests," "data□driven," "career□ready standards," "project□based," "experiential," "social□emotional learning," etc., and by state□compliance jargon.
- **Best category:** Parents & Community is the least non□classical (some partnership language), but still framed in modern accountability terms.

Because the overall rating is **NOT CLASSICAL**, a "What would move the needle" section is optional, but I will still include a brief one at the end for clarity.

Method: Keyword□Based Classicality Audit

I used the **Six Essential Elements of a Classical School** keyword framework (positive and negative indicators) across the six categories: Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, Purpose & Goal, Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, Parents & Community.

For each category I:

1. **Extracted phrases** from the crawl of ccswhiteville.net. –
 2. **Matched** them against the positive/negative keyword lists (e.g., truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, scholé, wonder, chanting, Socratic vs. project□based, experiential learning, data□driven, college□and□career ready, etc.).
 3. **Counted hits** and estimated the ratio of positive to negative indicators.
 4. Assigned a rating: **CLASSICAL / SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL / NOT CLASSICAL**.
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CATEGORY 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations

1.1. Observed Keywords / Phrases from the Crawl

From the School-Based Mental Health Plan and improvement documents:

- “disciplined, caring classroom environment that emphasizes **traditional values** and direct instructional methods”
- “student mental and physical health are integral parts of a foundation for academic success”
- “sense of well-being,” “safe and secure in their learning environment,” “mental health plan,” “social worker,” “school-based counseling services,” “Say Something Anonymous reporting system,” “character education and health curriculum”

Notably absent across the crawl:

- No “truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, wisdom, moral order, natural law, transcendence, permanent things, formation of the soul, telos, great conversation” etc.
- No “theology, Christ-centered, Christian worldview, sacred scripture, catechesis, liturgy, chapel, worship, Eucharist, prayer, reverence, sacred music, hymnody.”

1.2. Positive vs. Negative Lexicon Hits

Using the Religious & Metaphysical lexicon:

- **Positive indicators found (approx.):**
 - “traditional values” – 1 weak hit (could align with “classical virtues” but is vague and not tied to transcendental moral realism).
- **Negative / modernist indicators:**
 - “values-based” style language around mental health and character education, but **without** theological or transcendental grounding.
 - Heavy emphasis on **mental health, well-being, safety, support services, social-emotional group lessons, mental health training**, etc., which are neutral in themselves but, in the absence of any transcendent or theological language, align with a **secular, therapeutic** rather than classical metaphysical frame.

Estimated ratio:

- Positive metaphysical/theological keywords: about **1**
- Negative/neutral-secular indicators: **15+**

Percent positive: about **0.05–0.10**

Percent coverage of classical metaphysical criteria: **near 0** (no explicit transcendental moral realism, theology, or liturgy).

1.3. Rating

Rating: NOT CLASSICAL

The school appears **secular and therapeutic**, not grounded in theology or transcendental moral realism, and has no liturgical or sacred communal practices evident in the crawl.

CATEGORY 2: School Purpose and Goal

2.1. Observed Keywords / Phrases

From mission-aligned language in the mental health plan and improvement documents:

- “foundation for academic success”
- “student proficiency,” “proficiency data,” “academic and proficiency growth,” “school performance data,” “school accountability model,” “educator effectiveness model,” “standardized tests,” “test preparation,” “measures mastery of grade-level content standards”
- “skills for effective expression, communication, and understanding of how they fit into this world, with a love for learning and discovery” (from the mental health plan referencing the mission statement)

Absent:

- No explicit “wisdom, virtue, human flourishing, formation, soul, telos, truth, goodness, beauty, liberal education, scholé, education for leisure, great conversation.”

2.2. Positive vs. Negative Lexicon Hits

From the “Philosophical and Educational Goals” lexicon:

- **Positive indicators:**
 - “love for learning and discovery” – 1 partial hit (could align with “love of learning,” “wonder,” but not tied to virtue/wisdom or transcendentals).
- **Negative indicators:**
 - Strong presence of “academic success,” “student achievement,” “proficiency data,” “standardized assessments,” “school accountability model,” “educator effectiveness model,” “data-informed,” “results-focused,” etc., which are explicitly listed as negative indicators of “formation, not information” in the Six Elements document.

Estimated ratio:

- Positive classical purpose keywords: **1–2** (weak)
- Negative “information/metrics/skills” keywords: **20+**

Percent positive: about **0.05**

Percent coverage of classical purpose criteria: **very low.**

2.3. Rating

Rating: NOT CLASSICAL

The telos of education here is framed in terms of **academic success, proficiency, and compliance with state accountability**, not the cultivation of wisdom and virtue ordered to truth, goodness, and beauty.

CATEGORY 3: Curriculum

3.1. Observed Keywords / Phrases

From testing calendar and improvement plans:

- Curriculum references are generic: “math core classes,” “reading and math core classes,” “math curriculum night,” “character education and health curriculum,” “curriculum will provide new material and platforms to address the current needs of students.”
- Heavy emphasis on **state tests**: BOG3, EOGs, WIDA, Read to Achieve, Extend1, etc., all tied to “grade□level content standards” and accountability.

Absent:

- No mention of **Trivium, Quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, liberal arts, Latin, Greek, Great Books, primary sources, Great Conversation, Western civilization, classical literature, Socratic texts, recitation, narration.**
- History is only implied via “social studies” style state standards; the crawl does not show “history” as a distinct, chronologically taught discipline or “Western civilization.”

3.2. Positive vs. Negative Lexicon Hits

Using the Curriculum lexicon:

- **Positive indicators:**
 - Essentially **0**: no trivium/quadrivium, no Great Books, no Latin, no explicit “history” emphasis, no “wonder” language in curricular descriptions.
- **Negative indicators:**
 - Strong presence of **standardized testing**, “grade□level content standards,” “data□driven,” “assessment□driven instruction,” which are associated with non□classical, outcome□driven curricula.
 - The improvement plan mentions “curriculum will provide new material and platforms to address the current needs of students,” which aligns with **modern, platform□driven, needs□based** curriculum language rather than classical inheritance.

Estimated ratio:

- Positive classical curriculum keywords: **0**
- Negative/modernist curriculum indicators: **10+**

Percent positive: 0.00

Percent coverage: 0.00 (no evidence of classical curriculum structure).

3.3. Rating

Rating: NOT CLASSICAL

Curriculum is **state□standards and test□driven**, with no sign of the seven liberal arts, Great Books, or historically rooted, wonder□oriented content.

CATEGORY 4: Pedagogy / Teaching Methods

4.1. Observed Keywords / Phrases

From improvement plans and mental□health plan:

- “direct instructional methods” (explicitly named)

- “math tutoring,” “afternoon intervention time,” “MTSS,” “intervention/support,” “weekly check-ins,” “social/emotional group lesson,” “professional development,” “data-driven decisions,” “performance data,” etc.
- “disciplined, caring classroom environment,” “high expectations for diligence, discipline, and devotion to seeking knowledge.”

Absent:

- No “Socratic seminar, dialectic, guided discussion, great conversation, Harkness, disputation, debate, rhetoric exercises, orations.”
- No “scholé, restful learning, contemplation, unhurried learning, wonder-based education.”
- No “recitation, chanting, singing, memory work, catechism, copywork, imitation, progymnasmata.”

4.2. Positive vs. Negative Lexicon Hits

From the Pedagogy lexicon:

- **Positive indicators:**
 - “diligence” and “discipline” could be loosely related to virtue, but they are framed in a **behavioral/academic** context, not as part of contemplative, wonder-based pedagogy.
- **Negative indicators:**
 - “direct instruction,” “test-driven,” “standardized assessments,” “data-driven instruction,” “intervention time,” “MTSS,” “performance data,” etc., align with the **negative pedagogy** list (lecture-based, skills-based, test-driven, efficiency-oriented).

Estimated ratio:

- Positive classical pedagogy keywords: **0–1 (weak)**
- Negative/modernist pedagogy indicators: **15+**

Percent positive: about **0.05**

Percent coverage: **very low** (no Socratic, no scholé, no chanting/memory, no rhetoric).

4.3. Rating

Rating: NOT CLASSICAL

Pedagogy is **direct instruction + intervention + data-driven**, not Socratic, contemplative, or mimetic in the classical sense.

CATEGORY 5: Faculty

5.1. Observed Keywords / Phrases

From improvement plans:

- “Headmaster, Assistant Headmaster, Social Worker and 2 teachers will be trained in Mental Health First Aid.”
- “Leadership Team consisting of the principal, teachers who lead the Instructional Teams, and other professional staff meets regularly... to review implementation of effective practices.”

- “system of procedures and protocols for recruiting, evaluating, rewarding, and replacing staff.”
- “professional development provided at the beginning of each school year for teachers and staff delivered by school social worker and/or outside psychologist.”

Absent:

- No “teachers as models of virtue,” “living curriculum,” “faculty of friends,” “mentors,” “sages,” “portrait of a teacher,” “classical formation of faculty,” “great books seminars for faculty.”

5.2. Positive vs. Negative Lexicon Hits

From the Faculty lexicon:

- **Positive indicators:**
 - None explicitly. “Headmaster” is a traditional title but not itself a classical keyword.
- **Negative indicators:**
 - Strong bureaucratic/HR language: “system of procedures and protocols for recruiting, evaluating, rewarding, and replacing staff,” “professional development,” “teacher surveys,” “data-driven decisions,” which align with the **bureaucratic, certification-driven** model the Six Elements document contrasts with a “faculty of friends.”

Estimated ratio:

- Positive classical faculty keywords: **0**
- Negative/bureaucratic indicators: **10+**

Percent positive: 0.00

Percent coverage: 0.00

5.3. Rating

Rating: NOT CLASSICAL

Faculty are framed as **staff within a compliance-oriented system**, not as a collegium of mentors and exemplars of wisdom and virtue.

CATEGORY 6: Parents & Community

6.1. Observed Keywords / Phrases

From improvement plans and parent communication goals:

- “The school regularly communicates with parents/guardians about its expectations of them and the importance of the curriculum of the home (what parents can do at home to support their children’s learning).”
- “math curriculum night will be planned to provide parents with resources to assist their child at home with math curriculum.”
- “Headmaster will send weekly communications to families regarding current and upcoming events and news.”
- “parent sign-in sheets,” “parent letters,” “PowerSchool Parent Portal letter,” etc.

Absent:

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- No “parent partnership, co□educators, school as extension of the home, parent formation, classical book clubs, parent seminars on classical education, family catechesis, feasts and festivals, liturgical year events.”

6.2. Positive vs. Negative Lexicon Hits

From the Parents & Community lexicon:

- **Positive indicators:**
 - Some **generic partnership language**: “regularly communicates with parents,” “math curriculum night,” “resources to assist their child at home,” which partially align with “parent partnership” but are **content□neutral** (not specifically classical).
- **Negative indicators:**
 - No explicit negative phrases like “parents as customers,” but the relationship is framed in **informational and compliance** terms (letters, sign□in sheets, portal access) rather than shared classical formation.

Estimated ratio:

- Positive partnership□style keywords: **3–4 (weak)**
- Negative/neutral bureaucratic indicators: **5–7**

Percent positive: about **0.35–0.40**

Percent coverage of classical parent/community criteria: **low□moderate** (some partnership, no classical formation).

6.3. Rating

Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (low)

This is the **least non□classical** area: there is at least **intentional communication and some parent events**. However, it lacks the **distinctively classical** features (parent formation in classical ideas, co□teaching ethos, liturgical community life).

Aggregate Assessment

Summary of Category Ratings

1. **Religious & Metaphysical Foundations:** NOT CLASSICAL
2. **School Purpose & Goal:** NOT CLASSICAL
3. **Curriculum:** NOT CLASSICAL
4. **Pedagogy / Teaching Methods:** NOT CLASSICAL
5. **Faculty:** NOT CLASSICAL
6. **Parents & Community:** SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (weak)

Overall Classicality Status

Given:

- **Near-zero positive classical keyword coverage** in the core areas (1–5).
- **Strong presence of negative lexicon indicators:** standardized testing, data-driven instruction, accountability models, mental health/SEL frameworks, and bureaucratic HR language.
- **Absence** of any explicit classical markers (Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, Latin, Socratic, scholé, wonder, theology, liturgy, virtue/wisdom language).

Overall Rating: NOT CLASSICAL

This is a **state-aligned, “classical”-branded charter** whose public materials, as captured in the crawl, do not substantively reflect the six essential elements of a classical school.

What Would Move the Needle (If They Wanted to Become Classical)

Even though the overall rating is NOT CLASSICAL, here are concrete steps that would measurably shift the keyword profile and substance:

1. Religious & Metaphysical Foundations

- Explicitly articulate a **transcendental moral realist** vision: use and explain “truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, natural law, telos, permanent things.”
- If appropriate to their charter, ground the school in a **theological framework** (even if broadly Christian) and integrate language like “theology, faith and reason, sacred scripture, Christ-centered education, liturgy, worship, reverence.”

2. Purpose & Goal

- Reframe the mission around **formation, not information**: “cultivation of wisdom and virtue,” “formation of the soul,” “education ordered to the true, the good, and the beautiful,” “human excellence,” “liberal education.”
- De-emphasize test scores and accountability language in mission/vision pages; keep those in compliance documents, not as the school’s stated telos.

3. Curriculum

- Publicly commit to the **seven liberal arts**: name “grammar, logic, rhetoric, arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy” and show where they live in the program.
- Introduce and advertise **Latin** (and possibly Greek) and a **Great Books / primary-source humanities sequence**; use terms like “Great Books, Great Conversation, Western civilization, classical canon.”
- Replace “social studies” framing with **chronological history** and “Western civilization” plus world history.

4. Pedagogy

- Describe and implement **Socratic seminars, guided discussions, dialectic**, especially in upper grades; use those terms on the website.
- In lower grades, highlight **chanting, singing, recitation, memory work, copywork, imitation**; use those words explicitly.
- Introduce the language and practice of **scholé** and “restful learning,” emphasizing contemplation and wonder, not just rigor and test prep.

5. Faculty

- Publish a **“Portrait of a Classical Teacher”** that uses terms like “mentor, model of virtue, living curriculum, faculty of friends, lifelong learner, lover of wisdom.”

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- Describe ongoing **classical formation** for faculty (Great Books seminars, training in classical pedagogy).

6. **Parents & Community**

- Move beyond information nights to **parent formation**: classical book clubs, talks on classical education, and explicit language about parents as **co-educators** and the school as an **extension of the home**.

If future crawls show these kinds of changes—especially explicit use of the classical lexicon and corresponding structural changes in curriculum and pedagogy—the school's rating could move toward **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL** and eventually **CLASSICAL**.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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